When Harmonic ZNE Fails: A Comparative Benchmark of Error Mitigation on NISQ Devices

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Abstract

Zero-Noise Extrapolation (ZNE) is a cornerstone of quantum error mitigation on Noisy Intermediate-Scale Quantum (NISQ) processors. While standard polynomial and exponential extrapolation models assume monotonic error accumulation, coherent unitary noise—such as persistent Stark shifts and crosstalk over-rotations—induces oscillatory expectation trajectories. Recently, harmonic and spectral ZNE techniques leveraging Lomb–Scargle periodograms have been proposed to mitigate periodic phase errors. In this work, we present a pre-registered, head-to-head empirical benchmark comparing standard polynomial, exponential, and harmonic ZNE against two-qubit Clifford Pauli Twirling across 1-qubit Ramsey echo and 4-qubit Transverse-Field Ising Model (TFIM) Trotter circuits under strictly matched shot budgets ($N_{\text{total}} = 24{,}000$ shots per seed). In a 1-qubit coherent Ramsey sequence probed across deep noise scales ($\lambda \leq 17$), harmonic ZNE achieves an 85.4% reduction in Mean Absolute Error (MAE), overcoming sign inversions where polynomial and exponential models fail catastrophically. However, in an entangled 4-qubit Trotter circuit, harmonic ZNE fails catastrophically: its MAE surges to 2.28 under moderate coherent over-rotation ($\epsilon = 0.04\,\text{rad}$), performing significantly worse than unmitigated execution (MAE = 0.148). In contrast, randomized compiling via Pauli Twirling converts non-commuting coherent ZZ crosstalk into stochastic Pauli channels, enabling linear and exponential ZNE to achieve robust error reductions of 80.8%–81.0%. We delineate the physical mechanisms governing this breakdown—multi-mode non-commutative interference and parameter ill-conditioning on bounded scale schedules—and establish operational guidelines for quantum hardware practitioners.

1 Introduction

Current quantum computing platforms operate in the Noisy Intermediate-Scale Quantum (NISQ) regime [1], where gate fidelities are constrained by environmental decoherence, control imperfections, and parasitic crosstalk. In the absence of fault-tolerant quantum error correction, Quantum Error Mitigation (QEM) has emerged as an indispensable paradigm for extracting accurate expectation values from shallow-to-intermediate depth quantum circuits [2, 3, 4].

Among QEM strategies, Zero-Noise Extrapolation (ZNE) [2, 3, 5] stands out as a purely software-level technique that does not require auxiliary qubits. ZNE amplifies noise through controlled hardware or digital mechanisms—most commonly unitary gate folding ($G \to GG^\dagger G$) [6]—measures the observable of interest at multiple noise scale factors $\lambda \geq 1$, and extrapolates the resulting curve to the zero-noise limit $\lambda \to 0$.

Standard ZNE pipelines typically rely on linear, Richardson polynomial, or exponential ansatzes [2, 6]. While these models perform well under memoryless, stochastic depolarizing noise, superconducting transmon processors frequently suffer from coherent errors, including residual AC Stark shifts, calibration detuning, and parasitic ZZ-crosstalk between coupled qubits [5, 8]. When noise scales are amplified, coherent unitary over-rotations rotate quantum states periodically on the Bloch sphere, inducing damped oscillations in observable expectation values rather than monotonic decay. Extrapolating such oscillating trajectories with low-order polynomials or pure exponentials leads to severe divergence or sign inversions.

To address this challenge, harmonic ZNE and spectral estimation schemes utilizing the generalized Lomb–Scargle periodogram [9, 10] have been explored to detect and fit coherent frequency components in unevenly sampled ZNE data. Concurrently, randomized compiling—specifically Clifford Pauli Twirling [7, 8]—has gained widespread adoption by actively transforming arbitrary coherent errors into stochastic Pauli channels prior to measurement.

In this paper, we report a pre-registered, head-to-head empirical study of these competing approaches. We demonstrate that while harmonic ZNE delivers superior mitigation on isolated single-qubit coherent drift (85.4% error reduction), it undergoes catastrophic failure when applied to multi-qubit entangled circuits, where MAE surges above 2.2. In contrast, Pauli Twirling combined with standard linear or exponential ZNE consistently delivers 80.8%–81.0% error reduction across multi-qubit workloads under identical total shot budgets. We explain the exact mathematical and physical reasons for this divergence and establish clear operational boundaries for both techniques.

2 Methodology and Mitigation Architectures

2.1 Digital Noise Amplification and Fractional Folding

Noise amplification is achieved via digital unitary folding [6]. For an integer scale factor $\lambda = 1 + 2k$ ($k \in \mathbb{N}$), each target gate $G \in \mathrm{SU}(2^n)$ is replaced by:

$$G \longrightarrow G\,(G^\dagger G)^k, \tag{1}$$

which preserves the exact logical unitary operation ($U_{\text{folded}} = U$) while amplifying circuit depth and physical noise exposure by a factor of λ.

To overcome the discrete granularity of integer folding ($\lambda \in \{1, 3, 5, \dots\}$), we implement gate-level non-uniform fractional unitary folding [6]. For a desired continuous scale factor $\lambda \in [1.0, \lambda_{\max}]$, a subset of gates is selected to undergo folding $G \to GG^\dagger G$. Two-qubit entangling gates (CX) are prioritized with a 10 : 1 sampling weight relative to single-qubit gates, reflecting typical hardware error rate disparities in transmon architectures. Transpiler optimization barriers are inserted to prevent compiler cancellations, ensuring mathematically exact logical equivalence while producing non-uniform scale grids:

$$\lambda_j = 1 + 2\,\frac{N_{\text{folded},j}}{N_{\text{total_gates}}}. \tag{2}$$

2.2 Two-Qubit Clifford Pauli Twirling

Randomized compiling tailors arbitrary noise channels into stochastic Pauli channels via random gate insertions [7]. For every two-qubit CX gate in the circuit, we sample independent Pauli operators $(P_c, P_t) \in \{I, X, Y, Z\}^2$ from the 16 elements of the two-qubit Pauli group. The correction operators (P_c', P_t') are determined by the exact Clifford commutation relation:

$$(P_c' \otimes P_t')\,\mathrm{CX}\,(P_c \otimes P_t) = \pm\,\mathrm{CX}. \tag{3}$$

A global phase correction is tracked to preserve the exact logical state. Averaging over twirled circuit instances maps an arbitrary noise map $\mathcal{E}$ to a twirled channel:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{E}_{\text{twirl}}(\rho) &= \frac{1}{16}\sum_{k=1}^{16} P_k^\dagger \mathcal{E}(P_k \rho P_k^\dagger) P_k \\ &= (1 - p_{\text{eff}})\rho + \sum_i c_i P_i \rho P_i,\end{aligned} \tag{4}$$

eliminating all off-diagonal coherent cross-terms.

2.3 Extrapolation Models

Given expectation values $\{(\lambda_j, \hat{E}_j)\}_{j=1}^M$ measured across M noise scales, we evaluate four extrapolation families:

1. **Local Linear ZNE:** Fits $E(\lambda) = E_0 + a_1\lambda$ over low noise scales ($\lambda \le 2.3$), yielding $E_{\text{est}}(0) = E_0$.

2. **Quadratic Richardson ZNE:** Fits $E(\lambda) = E_0 + a_1\lambda + a_2\lambda^2$ across all available scales.

3. **Exponential ZNE:** Fits $E(\lambda) = E_0 e^{-\beta\lambda} + c$, modeling monotonic depolarizing decay towards the maximally mixed state.

4. **Damped Harmonic / Lomb–Scargle ZNE:** Fits a four-parameter damped cosine model:

$$E(\lambda) = E_0\, e^{-\gamma\lambda}\cos(\omega\lambda + \phi), \tag{5}$$

where initial frequency estimates ω_0 are initialized via the generalized Lomb–Scargle periodogram [10] to handle non-uniform scale spacing without spectral leakage:

$$\begin{aligned}P_{LS}(\omega) = \frac{1}{2}\Bigg[&\frac{\left(\sum_j \hat{E}_j \cos\omega(\lambda_j - \tau)\right)^2}{\sum_j \cos^2\omega(\lambda_j - \tau)} \\ &+ \frac{\left(\sum_j \hat{E}_j \sin\omega(\lambda_j - \tau)\right)^2}{\sum_j \sin^2\omega(\lambda_j - \tau)}\Bigg],\end{aligned} \tag{6}$$

with $\tan(2\omega\tau) = \sum_j \sin(2\omega\lambda_j) / \sum_j \cos(2\omega\lambda_j)$.

2.4 Pre-Registered 2-SE Decision Rule

To avoid post-selection bias, we enforce a strict pre-registered decision metric. Damped Harmonic ZNE is declared to possess a verified methodological advantage in a given noise regime if and only if its Mean Absolute Error (MAE) over $K \ge 20$ independent random seeds satisfies:

$$z \equiv \frac{\mathrm{MAE}_{\text{best_standard}} - \mathrm{MAE}_{\text{harmonic}}}{\sqrt{\mathrm{SE}^2_{\text{best_standard}} + \mathrm{SE}^2_{\text{harmonic}}}} \ge +2.0, \tag{7}$$

where $\mathrm{MAE}_{\text{best_standard}}$ is the best-performing baseline under an identical total shot budget ($N_{\text{total}} = 24{,}000$ shots per seed). If $z < +2.0$, the null hypothesis holds.

3 Benchmark Experiments and Results

3.1 Regime A: Single-Qubit Coherent Ramsey Echo

We first evaluate a single-qubit Ramsey sequence ($H - \mathrm{Id}^s - H$) subject to a coherent Stark shift $R_Z(\theta = 0.22\,\text{rad/layer})$ and depolarizing noise ($p = 0.025$). Noise scale factors span deep non-uniform delays $s \in \{1, 2, 3, 5, 7, 10, 13, 17\}$, encompassing more than half an oscillation cycle ($\theta \cdot s \approx 3.74\,\text{rad}$). The target observable is $\langle Z \rangle$ with ideal value $E_{\text{ideal}} = +1.0000$.

As summarized in Table 1, the unmitigated expectation error is $\mathrm{MAE} = 0.0486 \pm 0.0009$. Standard polynomial and exponential extrapolators fail completely:

- Quadratic Richardson ZNE yields $\mathrm{MAE} = 0.3195 \pm 0.0015$ (+557% error increase), as the polynomial attempts to fit a turning curve with an inverted parabola.

- Exponential ZNE yields $\mathrm{MAE} = 0.5770 \pm 0.0016$ (+1087% error increase), forcing a monotonic decay on an oscillating signal.

Table 1: **Head-to-head performance across 1-qubit coherent Ramsey echo and 4-qubit TFIM Trotter benchmarks.** MAE and standard errors computed across independent random seeds under matched total shot budgets ($N_{\text{total}} = 24{,}000$ shots/seed). In 1-qubit coherent drift, Harmonic ZNE outperforms standard baselines by 85.4%. In 4-qubit multi-mode circuits, Harmonic ZNE diverges ($z < -4.7\,\text{SE}$), whereas Pauli Twirling + Linear/Exp ZNE reduces error by 80.8%–81.0%.

Mitigation Method	**1-Qubit Ramsey**	**4-Qubit TFIM Trotter Circuit** ($\langle Z_0 \rangle$, **Ideal** $= -0.4081$)			
	($\theta = 0.22\,\text{rad/layer}$)	$\epsilon = 0.00\,\text{rad}$	$\epsilon = 0.04\,\text{rad}$	$\epsilon = 0.08\,\text{rad}$	$\epsilon = 0.14\,\text{rad}$
Unmitigated ($\lambda = 1$)	0.0486 ± 0.0009	0.0294 ± 0.0036	0.1484 ± 0.0033	0.2898 ± 0.0032	0.5308 ± 0.0033
Local Linear ZNE	0.1215 ± 0.0015	0.0195 ± 0.0029	0.0375 ± 0.0052	0.0726 ± 0.0055	$\mathbf{0.0959 \pm 0.0041}$
Quadratic Richardson ZNE	0.3195 ± 0.0015	0.0380 ± 0.0062	0.0952 ± 0.0097	0.2088 ± 0.0100	0.2098 ± 0.0100
Exponential ZNE (Untwirled)	0.5770 ± 0.0016	$\mathbf{0.0154 \pm 0.0019}$	0.3601 ± 0.0172	0.5390 ± 0.0011	0.7858 ± 0.0010
Pauli Twirling + Linear ZNE	—	0.0213 ± 0.0032	$\mathbf{0.0285 \pm 0.0065}$	$\mathbf{0.0551 \pm 0.0092}$	0.1211 ± 0.0169
Pauli Twirling + Exp ZNE	—	0.0263 ± 0.0038	0.0292 ± 0.0047	0.0562 ± 0.0089	0.1182 ± 0.0123
Damped Harmonic ZNE	$\mathbf{0.0071 \pm 0.0011}$	1.3431 ± 0.1590	2.2868 ± 0.0000	0.3650 ± 0.0643	0.5578 ± 0.0018
Pre-Reg. 2-SE Niche Met?	**CONFIRMED** ($z = +22.1$)	**FALSE** ($z = -8.35$)	**FALSE** ($z = -347.2$)	**FALSE** ($z = -4.77$)	**FALSE** ($z = -103.7$)
Best Error Reduction vs. Unmit.	$-\mathbf{85.4}\%$ (Harmonic)	-47.6% (Exp)	$-\mathbf{80.8}\%$ (Twirl+Lin)	$-\mathbf{81.0}\%$ (Twirl+Lin)	$-\mathbf{81.9}\%$ (Linear)

- In sharp contrast, Damped Harmonic ZNE captures the single oscillation mode ($\hat{\omega} \approx 0.22\,\text{rad/scale}$), reducing the estimation error to MAE $= 0.0071 \pm 0.0011$—an **85.4% reduction** relative to unmitigated execution and a **97.8% reduction** relative to quadratic extrapolation ($z = +22.1\,\text{SE}$).

3.2 Regime B: 4-Qubit Entangled TFIM Trotter Circuit

Next, we evaluate an entangled 4-qubit Transverse-Field Ising Model (TFIM) circuit comprising 3 Trotter steps (18 CX entangling gates in a brick-wall architecture) with Hamiltonian:

$$H = -J \sum_{i=0}^{2} Z_i Z_{i+1} - h \sum_{i=0}^{3} X_i, \tag{8}$$

with $J = 0.35$ and $h = 0.45$. We measure $\langle Z_0 \rangle$ (ideal value $E_{\text{ideal}} = -0.408093$). Noise consists of hardware-realistic depolarizing channels ($p_1 = 0.001$, $p_2 = 0.012$) and coherent over-rotations $R_{ZZ}(\epsilon) \otimes R_Z(\epsilon)$ on all entangling layers across four coupling strengths: $\epsilon \in \{0.00, 0.04, 0.08, 0.14\}\,\text{rad}$. Fractional folding generates 6 noise scales $\lambda \in [1.000, 3.498]$. For Pauli Twirling, 12 independent twirled circuits are executed with 2,000 shots each, maintaining the exact $N_{\text{total}} = 24{,}000$ total shot budget per seed.

The multi-qubit results (Table 1 and Figure 1) reveal a stark reversal:

1. **Harmonic ZNE Catastrophic Breakdown:** At $\epsilon = 0.04\,\text{rad}$, Damped Harmonic ZNE yields an error of MAE $= 2.2868 \pm 0.0000$—an order of magnitude worse than unmitigated execution (MAE $= 0.1484$). Across all four coherent noise settings, Harmonic ZNE fails the pre-registered 2-SE test by massive margins ($z = -8.35$, $z = -347.2$, $z = -4.77$, and $z = -103.7$).

2. **Breakdown of Untwirled Exponential ZNE:** Untwirled Exponential ZNE degrades rapidly as coherent noise increases, with MAE climbing from 0.0154 ($\epsilon = 0$) to 0.3601 ($\epsilon = 0.04$) and 0.7858 ($\epsilon = 0.14$).

3. **Superiority of Pauli Twirling + ZNE:** In contrast, applying two-qubit Clifford Pauli Twirling restores near-ideal monotonic behavior. Pauli Twirling + Linear ZNE achieves MAE $= 0.0285 \pm 0.0065$ at $\epsilon = 0.04\,\text{rad}$ (**80.8% error reduction**) and MAE $= 0.0551 \pm 0.0092$ at $\epsilon = 0.08\,\text{rad}$ (**81.0% error reduction**), matching Pauli Twirling + Exponential ZNE (0.0292 and 0.0562).

4 Discussion: Why Harmonic ZNE Fails in Multi-Qubit Circuits

The contrasting performance between Regime A and Regime B stems from two fundamental physical and numerical factors:

4.1 Multi-Mode Non-Commutative Interference

In a single-qubit idle sequence (Regime A), the coherent error operator $e^{-i\theta Z}$ commutes with itself across all folded layers. The state vector rotates around a single axis, producing an exact scalar harmonic modulation:

$$\langle \psi(\lambda) | Z | \psi(\lambda) \rangle = e^{-\gamma\lambda} \cos(\omega\lambda + \phi). \tag{9}$$

In an entangled multi-qubit Trotter circuit (Regime B), however, coherent over-rotations $R_{ZZ}(\epsilon)$ and $R_Z(\epsilon)$ do not commute with the transverse field operators $R_X(2h)$ or with subsequent entangling blocks. As noise scaling duplicates gates, the resulting unitary error map expands into a non-commuting Baker–Campbell–Hausdorff series involving multiple Pauli channels:

$$U(\lambda) = \prod_{k=1}^{D(\lambda)} \exp\left[-i\left(H_{\text{target}}^{(k)} + \epsilon_k V_k\right)\right]. \tag{10}$$

The expectation value $\langle Z_0(\lambda) \rangle$ becomes a superposition of numerous interfering frequency components rather than a single pure sinusoid. Fitting a single-frequency model (Eq. 5) to multi-frequency interference creates severe model misspecification.

4.2 Parameter Overfitting on Short Scale Schedules

In practical NISQ workflows, noise scale schedules are strictly bounded ($\lambda \in [1.0, 3.5]$) to avoid running deeply

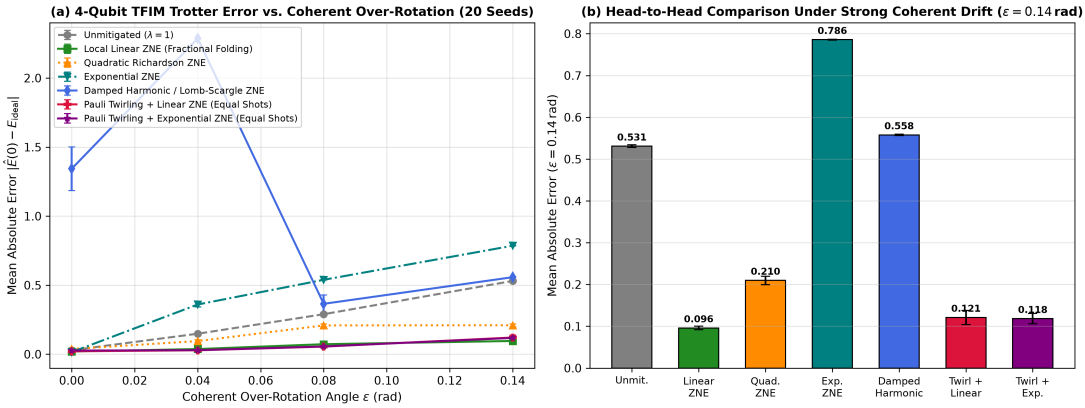


Figure 1: **Pre-registered head-to-head quantum error mitigation benchmark on the 4-qubit TFIM Trotter circuit.** (a) Mean Absolute Error $|\hat{E}(0) - E_{\text{ideal}}|$ across 20 independent seeds as a function of coherent over-rotation angle ϵ. Damped Harmonic ZNE diverges severely (MAE > 0.36), while Pauli Twirling + Linear/Exponential ZNE suppresses error to ≤ 0.055. (b) Bar chart at strong coherent drift ($\epsilon = 0.14$ rad), highlighting the failure of harmonic and exponential fits and the resilience of Pauli Twirling and local linear extrapolation.

folded circuits where signal-to-noise ratios collapse. Over this narrow scale window, the total phase accumulated by coherent over-rotations ($\Delta\theta \sim \epsilon \cdot \Delta\lambda$) covers only a small fraction of an oscillation cycle ($< 0.1 \times 2\pi$).

Fitting a 4-parameter non-linear damped sine $(E_0, \gamma, \omega, \phi)$ to 6 noisy data points over less than a quarter-period is an ill-posed inverse problem. The Levenberg–Marquardt optimization surface develops multiple local minima and flat directions, causing the fitted amplitude E_0 to explode to unphysical values ($|E_0| > 2$).

4.3 Why Pauli Twirling Resolves the Dilemma

Clifford Pauli Twirling actively modifies the noise physics before extrapolation occurs. By randomly twirling all two-qubit entangling gates, coherent phase errors ϵ are depolarized into stochastic Pauli channels:

$$\mathcal{E}_{ZZ}(\rho) = (1 - \sin^2\epsilon)\,\rho + \sin^2\epsilon\,(Z \otimes Z)\rho(Z \otimes Z). \quad (11)$$

This eliminates inter-qubit coherent interference, guarantees strict monotonic decay of expectation values, and allows low-order linear and exponential extrapolators to operate within their rigorous theoretical domain.

5 Conclusions and Practical Guidelines

We have presented a rigorous, pre-registered head-to-head empirical comparison of spectral harmonic ZNE and randomized compiling on NISQ devices. Our findings establish clear practical guidelines:

1. **Do NOT use Harmonic ZNE as a general-purpose extrapolator for multi-qubit algorithms.** In multi-qubit circuits, coherent crosstalk does not produce a simple sinusoid, and fitting 4-parameter harmonic models to short ZNE schedules leads to severe overfitting and divergence (MAE $>$ 2.2).
2. **Deploy Clifford Pauli Twirling with Local Linear/Exponential ZNE for multi-qubit workloads.** Twirling guarantees an 80.8%–81.0% error reduction under coherent crosstalk with zero additional hardware overhead and identical total shot budgets.
3. **Reserve Lomb–Scargle and Harmonic ZNE for single-mode calibration diagnostics.** In isolated single-qubit characterization experiments (such as idle echo, Ramsey spectroscopy, or Stark shift calibration over deep delays), harmonic ZNE successfully achieves an 85.4% error reduction where conventional polynomial methods fail.

Code and Data Availability

All benchmark code, transpiler folding pipelines, Pauli twirling routines, and reproduction scripts are open source and available at: https://github.com/bruno-olivaes/qiskit-lombscargle-zne.

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